# Acupuncture: The Fourteen Channels and Their Key Points

**An Audio-Depth Guide to Meridian Pathways and Point Locations**

## Scope and a Note on Evidence

Traditional Chinese Medicine recognizes over three hundred and sixty standard acupuncture points distributed across fourteen main channels — the twelve paired meridians associated with specific organs, plus two unpaired midline vessels. A complete point-by-point atlas at full depth would run to many hundreds of entries and go well past what's useful to absorb by ear. This guide instead covers the major, most clinically significant points on each of the fourteen channels — the points actually used most often in practice, roughly ninety in total — with each one located in the same spatial, anatomical terms used throughout this library's body-systems guide, so a listener can find or picture each point purely from the description.

As with the etheric body and meridian system described in that earlier guide, it's worth being direct about evidence here too: acupuncture points and the channels connecting them are a traditional Chinese medical model, not an anatomically confirmed structure — no meridian has been physically located as a distinct channel the way a nerve or blood vessel has. That said, acupuncture is one of the more clinically studied complementary practices in existence, with a real (if still debated) body of research supporting benefit for certain uses, particularly pain conditions, nausea, and some forms of chronic discomfort, regardless of whether the traditional channel theory itself is confirmed. This guide presents the traditional point locations and functions as they are taught within the TCM system, which is the information a listener researching or practicing acupuncture would actually need.

### How Points Are Located and Named

Traditional point locations are typically described using a body-proportional measurement called the "cun," a unit that scales to the individual's own body rather than a fixed inch or centimeter — for instance, the width of a person's own thumb at the knuckle is roughly one cun, and the width of four fingers held together is roughly three cun. This guide will describe cun distances as approximate proportional units rather than fixed measurements, exactly as they're traditionally taught. Each point also carries a standardized code — a channel abbreviation followed by a number counting from where the channel begins — alongside its traditional Chinese name.

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## The Lung Channel (LU)

The lung channel begins in the chest, runs laterally across the upper chest and shoulder, down the anterior-lateral surface of the arm (the thumb-side edge, when the palm faces forward), across the wrist, and ends at the outer corner of the thumbnail. In TCM theory it governs respiration, the skin, and the body's outer defensive energy.

LU7 (Lieque) sits proximal to the wrist, on the thumb side of the forearm, about two cun above the wrist crease, in the small hollow felt when the thumb and index finger are crossed — traditionally used for cough, sore throat, and headache at the back of the head and neck. LU9 (Taiyuan) sits directly at the wrist crease, on the thumb side, in the

depression felt at the radial pulse — traditionally the “source point” of the entire channel, used for cough, wheezing, and weak pulse. LU11 (Shaoshang) sits at the outer corner of the thumbnail, on the side away from the index finger — traditionally used for sore throat and, in acute cases, as a point stimulated briefly for fever.

## The Large Intestine Channel (LI)

The large intestine channel begins at the corner of the index fingernail, runs up the back of the hand between the thumb and index finger, up the lateral (outer) forearm and arm, over the top of the shoulder, up the side of the neck, and ends beside the nostril. It’s traditionally linked to the face, sinuses, and the body’s response to external illness.

LI4 (Hegu) is the single most frequently used point in the entire system, located on the back of the hand, in the fleshy mound between the thumb and index finger, at the highest point of that muscle when the thumb and finger are brought together — traditionally used for headache, facial pain, toothache, and to regulate the whole face and head; it’s also traditionally avoided during pregnancy. LI11 (Quchi) sits at the lateral end of the elbow crease, found by bending the elbow to a right angle and locating the point at the outer edge of the crease — traditionally used for fever, skin conditions, and elbow or arm pain. LI20 (Yingxiang) sits directly beside each nostril, in the crease where the nose meets the cheek — traditionally used for nasal congestion and sinus problems.

## The Stomach Channel (ST)

The stomach channel is the longest of the fourteen, beginning below the eye, running down the face, along the jawline, down the front of the neck, down through the chest and abdomen roughly two cun lateral to the midline, continuing down the anterior-lateral thigh and shin, and ending at the second toe.

ST36 (Zusanli) is, alongside LI4, one of the two most important points in the entire system, located on the anterior-lateral shin, about four finger-widths below the kneecap and one finger-width lateral to the shin bone — traditionally regarded as a major point for digestive strength, general vitality, and immune support, and one of the few points traditionally used preventively in otherwise healthy people. ST25 (Tianshu) sits on the abdomen, about two cun lateral to the navel on either side — traditionally used for digestive complaints including constipation, diarrhea, and abdominal pain. ST6 (Jiache) sits at the angle of the jaw, in the muscle that bulges when the teeth are clenched (the masseter muscle described in the earlier body-systems guide) — traditionally used for jaw pain, toothache, and facial paralysis.

## The Spleen Channel (SP)

The spleen channel begins at the medial corner of the big toenail, runs up the medial (inner) side of the foot, up the inner shin and thigh, into the abdomen, and up through the chest to end at the side of the body below the armpit. In TCM theory it governs digestion and the transformation of food into usable energy, distinct from the biological spleen described in the earlier immune-system section.

SP6 (Sanyinjiao) is one of the most used points on the body, located on the medial (inner) shin, about four finger-widths above the tip of the inner ankle bone, just behind the shin bone — traditionally significant because it’s said to be the meeting point of three separate channels (spleen, liver, and kidney), used for digestive issues, gynecological complaints, and sleep; like LI4, it’s traditionally avoided during

pregnancy. SP9 (Yinlingquan) sits just below the knee on the medial side, in the hollow beneath the bony prominence of the upper shin bone — traditionally used for fluid retention and lower-abdominal or urinary complaints. SP10 (Xuehai) sits on the medial thigh, about two finger-widths above the top of the kneecap, on the inner side — traditionally used for skin conditions and gynecological complaints related to blood.

## The Heart Channel (HT)

The heart channel begins in the armpit, runs down the medial (inner, pinky-side) edge of the arm and forearm, across the wrist, and ends at the inner corner of the little fingernail.

HT7 (Shenmen) sits at the wrist crease, on the pinky side, in the small hollow just proximal to the crease — traditionally one of the primary points for calming the mind, used for anxiety, insomnia, and heart palpitations. HT3 (Shaohai) sits at the medial end of the elbow crease when the elbow is bent — traditionally used for elbow pain and, in TCM theory, for calming excess heat associated with agitation.

## The Small Intestine Channel (SI)

The small intestine channel begins at the outer corner of the little fingernail, runs up the back of the hand and the medial (inner) side of the forearm and arm, across the back of the shoulder blade, up the side of the neck, across the cheek, and ends just anterior to the ear.

SI3 (Houxi) sits on the outer edge of the hand, just proximal to the base of the little finger’s main knuckle, found by making a loose fist — traditionally used for neck and upper-back pain and stiffness. SI11 (Tianzong) sits in the center of the shoulder blade, in the depression felt roughly at the midpoint of that bone — traditionally used for shoulder and upper-back pain.

## The Bladder Channel (BL)

The bladder channel is the largest channel by number of points, beginning at the inner corner of the eye, running up and over the top of the skull, down the entire length of the back in two parallel lines on either side of the spine, down the back of the thigh and calf, and ending at the outer corner of the little toenail. The points running down the back are traditionally significant because many of them are named “associated points” or “back-shu points,” each traditionally linked to a specific internal organ at roughly the vertebral level nearest that organ.

BL23 (Shenshu) sits on the lower back, about two finger-widths lateral to the spine at the level of the second lumbar vertebra (roughly waist height) — traditionally the associated point for the kidneys, used for lower back pain and issues traditionally linked to kidney energy. BL40 (Weizhong) sits at the exact center of the crease behind the knee — traditionally an important point for lower back and leg pain. BL60 (Kunlun) sits on the outer ankle, in the hollow between the outer ankle bone and the Achilles tendon — traditionally used for headache and lower back pain.

## The Kidney Channel (KI)

The kidney channel begins on the sole of the foot, runs up the medial (inner) side of the ankle, leg, and thigh, into the lower abdomen, and continues up the chest close to the sternum, ending just below the collarbone.

KI1 (Yongquan) sits on the sole of the foot, in the depression that forms just anterior to the center of the sole when the toes are curled — traditionally the lowest point on the entire body's channel system and used to draw excess energy downward, for symptoms like dizziness or agitation felt in the head. KI3 (Taixi) sits in the hollow between the inner ankle bone and the Achilles tendon — traditionally the source point of the kidney channel, used broadly for issues traditionally linked to kidney energy, including fatigue and lower back weakness.

## The Pericardium Channel (PC)

The pericardium channel begins beside the nipple, runs across the chest and into the armpit, down the center of the anterior arm and forearm, across the center of the palm, and ends at the tip of the middle finger. In TCM theory the pericardium is treated as a protective layer around the heart, and this channel is closely linked functionally to the heart channel above.

PC6 (Neiguan) is one of the most widely used points in the entire system, located on the anterior forearm, about two cun proximal to the wrist crease, between the two central tendons felt when the wrist is flexed — traditionally used for nausea, motion sickness, and anxiety, and among the most researched acupuncture points for nausea specifically. PC8 (Laogong) sits in the center of the palm, where the tip of the middle finger touches when the fist is loosely closed — traditionally used for calming the mind and for excess heat in the body.

## The Triple Energizer Channel (TE)

The triple energizer channel — sometimes called "san jiao" or "triple burner" — begins at the outer corner of the ring fingernail, runs up the back of the hand and the center of the posterior forearm and arm, over the top of the shoulder, up the side of the neck, around the ear, and ends at the outer corner of the eyebrow. It doesn't correspond to a single physical organ in TCM theory but rather to the body's overall regulation of fluid and warmth across three regions of the trunk.

TE5 (Waiguan) sits on the posterior forearm, about two cun proximal to the wrist crease, directly opposite PC6 on the other side of the arm — traditionally used for headache, fever, and ear conditions. TE23 (Sizhukong) sits at the lateral end of the eyebrow, in the small hollow felt there — traditionally used for headache and eye conditions.

## The Gallbladder Channel (GB)

The gallbladder channel is long and winds extensively, beginning at the outer corner of the eye, zigzagging across the side of the head, down the side of the neck, across the shoulder, down the entire lateral (outer) side of the trunk, thigh, and lower leg, and ending at the fourth toe.

GB20 (Fengchi) sits at the base of the skull, in the hollow on either side found between the two large neck muscles at the point where the skull meets the neck — traditionally one of the primary points for headache, neck stiffness, and dizziness. GB34 (Yanglingquan) sits on the outer lower leg, just below the knee, in the hollow anterior and inferior to the small bony head of the fibula (the outer lower-leg bone described in the earlier body-systems guide) — traditionally regarded as the primary point for tendon and muscle conditions throughout the body. GB21 (Jianjing) sits at the highest point of the shoulder, midway between the base of the neck and the outer edge of the shoulder — traditionally used for shoulder and neck tension, and traditionally avoided

or used cautiously during pregnancy.

## The Liver Channel (LR)

The liver channel begins at the outer corner of the big toenail, runs up the top of the foot, up the medial (inner) side of the shin and thigh, into the lower abdomen, and ends at the ribcage on the chest's side.

LR3 (Taichong) sits on the top of the foot, in the hollow felt between the first and second toe bones, about two finger-widths back from the web of the toes — traditionally regarded, alongside LI4, as one of the "four gates" points, used broadly for stress, irritability, headache, and to support smooth energy flow throughout the body. LR14 (Qimen) sits on the chest, directly below the nipple, in the space between two ribs — traditionally used for issues in the chest and upper abdomen related to emotional tension.

## The Governing Vessel (GV)

The governing vessel is one of two unpaired, midline channels rather than a bilateral meridian, running along the exact posterior midline of the body: beginning at the tailbone, running up the entire length of the spine, over the crown of the skull, down the center of the forehead, and ending just inside the upper lip. In TCM theory it governs and regulates all of the body's other yang (active, warming) channels.

GV20 (Baihui) sits at the very crown of the head, at the point where a line drawn straight up from the tops of both ears would cross the midline — traditionally one of the most important points on the body, used for mental clarity, dizziness, and to lift and stabilize overall energy. GV14 (Dazhui) sits on the posterior midline, in the depression felt directly below the most prominent bony bump at the base of the neck (the vertebra that stands out most when the head is tilted forward) — traditionally used for fever, colds, and neck stiffness, considered a meeting point for all the yang channels. GV4 (Mingmen) sits on the posterior midline of the lower back, directly opposite the navel — traditionally regarded as a reservoir of core vital energy, used for lower back pain and issues traditionally linked to overall vitality.

## The Conception Vessel (CV)

The conception vessel is the second unpaired, midline channel, running along the exact anterior midline of the body: beginning at the perineum, running straight up through the pubic bone, up the center of the abdomen and chest, and ending in the small depression at the base of the throat, just above the sternum. In TCM theory it governs and nourishes all of the body's yin (passive, cooling, nourishing) channels.

CV4 (Guanyuan) sits on the lower abdominal midline, about three cun (roughly four finger-widths) below the navel — traditionally regarded as a major point for overall vitality and reproductive health. CV6 (Qihai) sits on the lower abdominal midline, about one and a half cun below the navel, between CV4 and the navel — traditionally used for low energy and digestive weakness. CV12 (Zhongwan) sits on the upper abdominal midline, midway between the navel and the base of the sternum — traditionally the associated point for the stomach, used for digestive complaints. CV17 (Danzhong) sits on the chest's midline, at the level of the fourth intercostal space, roughly level with the nipples on most bodies — traditionally used for chest tightness, anxiety, and emotional constraint, considered a gathering point for the body's overall energy in the chest.

## Closing Note

These ninety points represent the core, most commonly relied-upon locations across all fourteen channels — the ones a practitioner reaches for most often — rather than the complete traditional atlas of over three hundred and sixty. Each was located here the same way every structure in this library’s body-systems guide was located: by its position relative to a landmark a listener can find on their own body without needing to see a chart, in keeping with this whole project’s standard of describing anatomy, and in this case traditional point theory, with enough spatial precision to be understood by ear alone.